

WHY DO WE DOOMSCROLL: A SNEAKPEAK INSIDE THE BRAIN



Photo by Getty

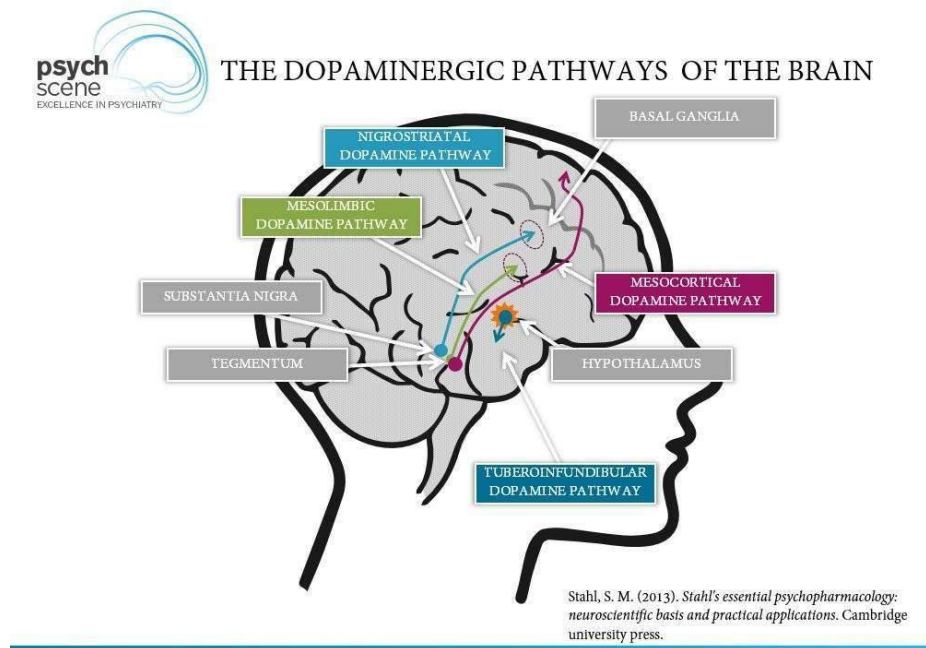
You take your phone to check the time and then BAM! An hour passes by, and you find yourself watching random people selling viral ‘Roshmalai cake’ by dancing on Dhaka Street. Well, you are not the only one. There is even a name for this activity, which we know as ‘Doomscrolling’. Even though we know it’s harmful for us and it will probably (read: definitely) won’t make us feel good, we still do it.

So, have you ever asked yourself what is happening inside your brain when you scroll endlessly?

Our intricate brain craves rewards and pleasure. It says, “this is fun, let’s watch one more reel” and we end up in an endless loop. Constant scrolling changes your brain’s three neuro pathways. These are **Mesocortical** (helps with memory, attention and learning), **Nigrostriatal** (For sensory stimuli), and **Mesolimbic** (for pleasure and reward seeking behaviors).¹ These activate when

¹ <https://sites.harvard.edu/sitn/2018/05/01/dopamine-smartphones-battle-time/>

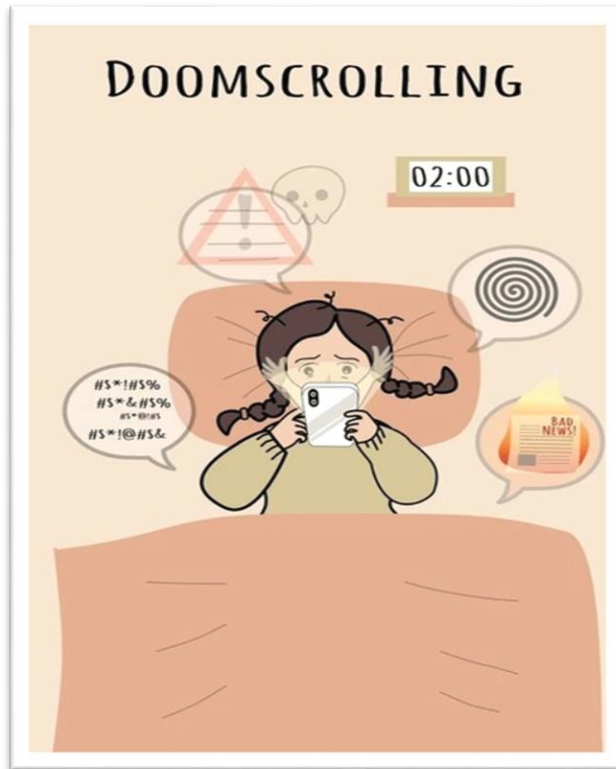
they receive rewards. TikTok, texts or Instagram act as a reward for your brain and change how these pathways usually work.



Dopamine Pathways by Psych Scene Hub

When you are scrolling without a care in this world, it rewards your brain and causes constant firing, which releases dopamine along in these pathways. That 'Spilling the Tea' text from your friend, or a reel acts as a mini reward which becomes stronger until you don't even notice that you are addicted to your phone.

Exploring the brain leads us to **Amygdala**, a tiny part of the brain region. This almond-shaped structure in each temporal lobe is a key part of the brain's limbic system, which plays a crucial role in emotions and memory. It is most known for processing fear, but it is also involved in decision-making, and learning, both positive and negative.



Constant exposure to news on Amygdala by Adobe stock

Amygdala triggers our fight or flight circuits. Our brain tends to pay more attention to threats and negative stimuli.² Therefore, we are more pulled towards negative news and amygdala keep making us scan for more and over time we are stuck in a loop or seeking new stimuli.

² UW Doomscroll, "How the Amygdala Drives Doomscrolling," YouTube, 2025.
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=aNvvOQMx0jY>



Blue Light from screen by Dreamstime.com

Lastly, one of the reasons we keep doomscrolling is the short wavelength blue light from phone or computer screens, which also suppresses Melatonin.³ Melatonin helps us to relax and sleep, but continuous scrolling interferes with Melatonin and keeps us awake (maybe you don't have insomnia, you just need to put the phone down, seriously!). An exhausted brain is more likely to repeat the habit, weakens self-control, and you slip back into doomscrolling.

ARE WE DOOMED? WHAT CAN WE DO ABOUT IT?

Breaking this habit isn't simple but possible. Marketing companies have studied these neuronal concepts and hijacked our brains into using their products more

³ <https://www.theguardian.com/lifeandstyle/2018/may/28/blue-light-led-screens-cancer-insomnia-health-issues#:~:text=In%20lab%20experiments%2C%20high%20exposure,%2C%E2%80%9D%20says%20O'Hagan>



Digital Detox by Getty

The fix? Limit social media use and overall screentime, swap your negative and uninformative feed with educational and mindful contents, which is good for your brain. And lastly, reset your brain by doing digital detox from time to time, connect with nature and save yourself from the vicious cycle.⁴

⁴ <https://www.verywellmind.com/why-and-how-to-do-a-digital-detox-4771321>